

FETCH.

Written by

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Connor Gaston

FADE IN:

INT. MANSION - OFFICE - DAY

We see the sky through an OPEN WINDOW.

NEWMAN (V.O.)
They expect me to give a eulogy,
you know.
(beat)
How would you want me to write it?

We scan the room. It's a quaint workspace, collecting dust on the top floor.

It's cluttered and disorganized; like a tornado came through the place. WIRES, METAL, and scraps of PAPER litter the floor as a large work desk gasps for air.

NEWMAN (50) walks in the room — a tall, rugged silver fox. Slicked back white hair. With a reluctant frown and jaded brow, he scoffs at the sight.

He glances at the WINDOW...it's CLOSED.

NEWMAN (V.O.)
(mockingly)
"One month later, and the world
remains in an outcry! Lest we
forget the tragic and sudden death
of technological renaissance man:
Colonel Oldman!"
(beat)
That's how the papers put it.
Maybe that's how *I* should put it.
They think they know you.
But they don't.

Newman crouches down, looking over the mess.
He rummages through the old scraps and springs.

NEWMAN (V.O.)
(mockingly)
"An old, lonely genius...
...Unrecognized for decades!
Until in his final years, he pushed
the button for the first time!"

From the mess, Newman picks up an old RED BUTTON; like one that you'd find on *The Price Is Right*. An empty BONE-SHAPED LABEL strikes through the middle, where a word can be written.

He gives it a press...

...a robotic VOICE.

CUT TO:

OVER BLACK.

BEGIN TITLES

BUTTON (O.S.)

FETCH.

END TITLES

CUT TO:

INT. MANSION - OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

Newman holds the BUTTON, now TURNED OVER.

"DOG DIALS!"

NEWMAN (V.O.)

(mockingly)

"Dog Dials! Where YOU can now
communicate with *man's best*
friend!"

(beat)

Man's best friend? To you?
Since when?

He drops it back into the pile and continues to survey the room.

NEWMAN (V.O.)

You never had time for friends.

(beat)

You never had time for *anyone*.

He looks to the work desk. An aged CATCHER'S MITT.

NEWMAN (V.O.)

There was *always* time to catch the
Reds...

(beat)

...But never the time to pitch.

A pause.

He walks out to the...

TOP FLOOR HALLWAY

NEWSPAPER CUTOUPS flood the walls. Only headlines of the Colonel, posed in PICTURES with various awards.

NEWMAN (V.O.)
And you died alone for it.

Newman keeps walking.

NEWMAN (V.O.)
I had finally erased you from my
memories.

He approaches the end of the hallway. There's an entrance to
an OPEN SPACE. Sunlight pokes through. He walks toward it.

NEWMAN (V.O.)
And here I am, looking through
yours, and it's like I never
existed.
(beat)
So why the hell did you leave me
with all of *this*!?

We look down to a vast, ritzy LOUNGING AREA. Elegant
furniture and modern art everywhere...collecting dust.
Regardless, this might as well be a palace.

Newman's disgusted by it.

LOUNGING AREA

Now on the ground floor, Newman ignores the pretentious
decor as he walks through...until he discovers a FRAMED
GLASS PORTRAIT of COLONEL.

As he approaches...fleeting, faded VOICES of journalists.

JOURNALISTS (V.O.)
The business, the family
fortune, everything now
passed on to his son. Poised
and eager to carry on his
father's legacy, just who is
this man they call--

NEWMAN (V.O.)
The business, the family
fortune, everything now
passed on to his son. Poised
and eager to carry on his
father's legacy, just who is
this man they call--

NEWMAN (V.O.)
Newman? Newman *Oldman*? What the
hell were you thinking?

He see's himself in his father's REFLECTION.

He shakes off his distaste, and moves into the...

GROUND FLOOR HALLWAY

More memories on the walls.

Newman sifts through them, nowhere to be found...

...except in ONE.

A POLAROID photo, tucked into a wooden frame. Carelessly placed, but there nonetheless. He picks it up.

It's father and son. Colonel looks serious; like he's trying too hard. An angry Monopoly man.

Sitting on the floor, turned away from his father is a toddler playing with a BASEBALL.

NEWMAN (V.O.)
Not even good enough for the top
floor, huh?

Newman keeps moving. He turns the corner and enters the...

KITCHEN

He STOPS.

The place is TORN APART, as if the Kitchen's been robbed. A TABLE and CHAIR for one, knocked over. The LOWER DOOR of the FRIDGE and all LOWER CUPBOARDS are open.

He looks to the door to the BACKYARD...

...wide open.

Newman investigates.

EXT. MANSION - BACKYARD - CONTINUOUS

The backyard is ripped to shreds. Random holes dug deep in the dirt. Every plant reaped of vegetation.

NEWMAN
(calling out)
Hello!?

He walks through the yard...An open GATE lies at the end.

Through it, a PATH. A 150-acre FOREST awaits.

He stares at it.

NEWMAN (V.O.)
Nothing's ever easy with you, is
it?

EXT. COLONEL'S FOREST - CONTINUOUS

Newman walks.

NEWMAN (V.O.)
"All good men need a quiet place,"
you'd say.
(beat)
Not so quiet now, you old bastard.

He looks upward.

NEWMAN (V.O.)
Wasn't every place your quiet
place?

Faint rays of sunlight poke through the treetops.

NEWMAN (V.O.)
You really needed all *this*?

A small RIVER runs through the woods. Newman approaches.

He looks in the WATER. A warped SELF-REFLECTION.

NEWMAN (V.O.)
Then again, look at me now.
Like father, like son, I suppose.

His focus lingers...

Enough. Time to look away.

He looks past the river...

...STUNNED.

A TATTERED BASEBALL sits alone in the dirt.

The river is small enough to hop across.

Newman LUNGES over.

He approaches the BALL.

He holds it in his hand...He studies it...

White leather...and BITE MARKS?

NEWMAN (V.O.)
There's no fucking way.

Newman scrambles for the old POLAROID photo.

He holds it up next to the BASEBALL.

NEWMAN (V.O.)
It can't be mine. An authentic
Johnny Bench...Cincinnati Reds...
...in black ink...

He checks each side...

...A fragmented word. "ENCH."

Anger.

Heavy breathing...HEAVY BREATHING...

NEWMAN
...FUCK YOU AND FUCK THE REDS--

CHOMP!

NEWMAN
AGH!!

TEETH sink in to Newman's HAND.

Something SNAGS the BALL...

...a DOG!?

Newman lands in the dirt, bewildered.

Knocked on his ass by a GERMAN SHEPHERD.

NEWMAN (V.O.)
Your one rule on game day.
"Never curse the Reds."

He watches it go.

The DOG SPRINTS...then runs...then limps.

A wounded STRAY - Tattered. Thin. Unkempt. Trying his best.

NEWMAN (V.O.)
Is this your way of mocking me?

The stray makes its way to a sizable CAVE.

Newman gets back up. He follows.

INT. CAVE - CONTINUOUS

Newman peers in. It's hard to see anything.

He takes a few steps forward.

He STEPS ON something...A robotic VOICE.

BUTTON

BOY.

Newman JUMPS BACK.

Newman looks down to his feet. A BUTTON.

He presses it with his shoe.

BUTTON

BOY.

NEWMAN

You have got to be kidding me.

Newman flips out a pocket LIGHTER.

WOOMPH! The CAVE is given LIGHT. Before him...

...A dwelling of BUTTONS.

They lay all around the floor; scattered, scratched, knocked over, and chewed on.

Dead-centre...the STRAY lies close to the ground.

The BASEBALL rests between his PAWS.

He stares at Newman.

NEWMAN

You're a thief.

The dog stays still. Watching. Observing.

Newman takes a step forward...CLICK.

BUTTON

WHERE.

NEWMAN

'Fuck sake.

The stray's EARS perk up. Alert.

Newman picks up the "WHERE" button.

He approaches the dog.

NEWMAN
I know it's neat, but none of this
belongs to you.

Newman *slowly* stretches out his good HAND...

BARK!

Newman jumps back!

He drops the BUTTON.

BUTTON
WHERE.

The stray's EARS go up again. It's landed in front of him.

He gives it a press.

STRAY
WHERE.

Entranced.

NEWMAN
Yes, that's what it does--

STRAY
WHERE.

NEWMAN
Okay, that's enough--

STRAY
WHERE.

Newman attempts to SNATCH the BUTTON back.

BARK! Newman backs off.

STRAY
WHERE.

Newman throws his head in his hands.
He collects himself. He considers the situation.

NEWMAN (V.O.)
Dog Dials. A technology to
communicate with Man's best friend.

Newman looks to the dog, still focused on the "WHERE"
BUTTON.

NEWMAN

Alright, you wanna play with more?

Newman walks around the cave, gathering nearby BUTTONS. He SITS DOWN across from the dog; a respectful eye-level. The dog watches carefully.

Newman lines up the buttons in ROWS. Each button has a word on the label. They're ILLEGIBLE; worn down by shepherd scratches and teeth marks.

Newman tries out each one.

NEWMAN

HELLO. MAN. GOOD. BALL. CHATTER.
DOG. IS. MASTER--

STRAY

WHERE--

NEWMAN

Stop it.

Newman tries again.

NEWMAN

HELLO. MAN. GOOD. BALL. CHATTER.
DOG. IS. MASTER. BOX. MINE. FETCH.
YOURS. HERE. GONE. YES. NO. FOOD.
HMM?

Newman takes out a PEN. He writes the appropriate WORD on each BUTTON, and lines them back up.

NEWMAN

Okay, you ready?

Newman attempts to communicate.

He points to the...

NEWMAN

BALL.

And points back to himself.

NEWMAN

MINE.

STRAY

MINE.

NEWMAN

Wait, what?

STRAY
MINE.

BARK!

Silence.

NEWMAN
BALL. MINE.

STRAY
NO. MINE.

NEWMAN
(to himself)
...Has he done this before?

STRAY
WHERE.

NEWMAN
Huh?

STRAY
WHERE. MASTER--

NEWMAN
Stop it. Just give me the ball--

STRAY
WHERE. MASTER. HMM?

NEWMAN
Cut that out.

STRAY
(faster)
WHERE. MASTER--

NEWMAN
I said STOP--

STRAY
(panicked)
WHERE. WHERE. WHERE. WHERE--

NEWMAN
FORGET IT!

The Stray is STARTLED by the SHOUT.

He loses focus on the BALL...it ROLLS freely.

THEY DIVE FOR IT.

They THRASH and FLAIL around the CAVE. This is war.

A war that a tattered stray cannot keep up with.

Newman SNAGS the BALL...it SLIPS out of his HANDS.

It bounces and lands near the cave's ENTRANCE.

Without thinking...Newman SHOVES the dog.

YELP!

The dog HITS the GROUND...

...triggering a BUTTON.

A HUMAN VOICE.

BUTTON
COLONEL.

Silence.

Newman is frozen. He forgets the ball. He approaches the
BUTTON.

Newman presses the button again; holding it close to his
ear.

BUTTON
COLONEL.

For the first time, it *really* hits him...

...He's gone.

Newman presses it one more time.

BUTTON
COLONEL.

STRAY
MASTER.

With heavy eyes, Newman looks to him.

His nose rests gently on the "MASTER" button.

Newman can't believe it.

STRAY
MASTER.
(beat)
WHERE. WHERE.
(MORE)

STRAY (CONT'D)
(beat)
...HMM?

Newman can't bear it.

He sits down in front of the dog.

NEWMAN
GONE.

A pause.

STRAY
MASTER. GONE. WHERE--

It's all too much.

NEWMAN
GONE. GONE. GONE. GONE. GONE.
(beat)
...GONE.

The dog gets up.

He motions toward the cave entrance...takes the BALL...

...and runs away.

EXT. FOREST - CONTINUOUS

Like a young pup, the dog BOLTS to the MANSION.

Newman CHASES. But he's no match for the Shepherd's speed.

He gives up the chase, but he follows...he watches...

The dog SPRINTS toward the RIVER.

Then, he runs.

Then, he walks.

Then, he stumbles.

Then...he falls.

Newman RUNS AS FAST AS HE CAN.

He approaches the RIVER. He kneels down.

The dog is...

...Okay. Exhausted, but not defeated.

The BALL rests safely in his mouth. Newman notices.

Newman leans in...and picks up the dog.

The dog, even still, keeps the BALL safe.

Newman struggles to stand up straight, but he presses on.

Once more over the river...

...and there's the REFLECTION.

A man carrying his father's dog.

INT. MANSION - KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

With the dog on his back, Newman returns to the knocked over CHAIR and the BLOWN OPEN LOWER CUPBOARDS.

Ready to faint, Newman sets him down gently.

They fall together; trying their best to process it all.

They look at each other, eye-level on the ground once again.

A shared, silent grieving.

INT. MANSION - KITCHEN - THE NEXT DAY

Newman awakens on the floor.

NEWMAN

Hey...

(beat)

...Where'd you go!?

The dog is nowhere to be found.

Newman stands up. He runs to the...

LIVING ROOM

Newman looks around desperately. Nothing.

Suddenly...SOUNDS from upstairs.

RUMMAGING.

Once more up to the...

TOP FLOOR HALLWAY

Newman walks by the framed newspapers again.

And into the...

OFFICE

And there he is.

The dog pokes his nose through the scrap metal.

A dog desperately clinging on to old memories.

Newman stands back, giving him room to process.

NEWMAN (V.O.)

They expect me to give a eulogy,
you know.

(beat)

How would you want me to write it?

(beat)

I thought I knew you.

(beat)

And trust me, I do.

(beat)

But I don't know everything.

The dog keeps digging.

NEWMAN (V.O.)

And neither does he.

The dog has let his guard down. The BASEBALL sits on the floor.

NEWMAN (V.O.)

...And maybe that's okay.

Newman grabs the BALL. The dog notices...he allows it.

Newman digs through the scrap metal.

He finds a BUTTON.

He takes it, and approaches the DESK.

He spots the OLD CATCHER'S MITT, still collecting dust...

...and puts it ON.

He approaches the WALL behind the desk.

We hear a LATCH UNLOCK.

We see the sky through an OPEN WINDOW.

Channelling the soul of the Cincinnati Reds...

Newman WINDS BACK...

A PITCH OUT THE WINDOW.

The dog SPRINGS UP.

And Newman SLAMS the BUTTON.

BUTTON
FETCH.

FADE OUT.